

Fall 2026 weekday crowding priority: certification

To: MBTA Board of Directors From: Commuter Rail service planning Date: 6 October 2026

Certified priority

The Board should certify the Fall 2026 weekday crowding priority as **Providence/Stoughton Line train 829** of the Fall 2024 count, outbound from South Station at 17:40, with a certified peak load of **1,064 riders leaving Ruggles at 17:49**. The Fall 2026 weekday schedule operates that train as **train 867**, leaving South Station at 17:37 and arriving Wickford Junction at 19:29, the same 13 stops the count recorded. The added coach set goes to train 867. Finance's draft (train 827, 896) and Planning's draft (train 723, 1,036) are not certified; the certified train's weekday boardings are 1,110, which is not a load.

The two draft figures: what each measured

Finance, train 827 at 896: not certified. Finance took the highest load among counted trains whose number also appears in the Fall 2026 schedule. The number is the only thing the two trains share. In the count, 827 leaves South Station at 16:52 with 896 riders leaving Ruggles; in the Fall 2026 schedule, 827 is an off peak train leaving South Station at 09:25. Train numbers were reassigned between the two schedules: of the 514 counted trains, 132 share a number with a Fall 2026 train on the same line and direction and only 2 of those still leave within ten minutes of the counted departure. The counted 827 is operated in Fall 2026 as train 861 at 16:52, and its 896 is only the sixth highest load in the count, shared with Needham Line train 606.

Planning, train 723 at 1,036: not certified. Train 723 is the runner up, and 1,036 is its correct peak load. It can only rank first if train 829 is set aside, and the one thing that distinguishes 829's count is that it does not reconcile to zero: the published load on leaving its last stop is -1, a rounding residue of averaged boardings (1,110) and alightings (1,111), where 723's count ends at 0. The convention certifies counts as published and adjusts none, and 57 of the 514 counted trains carry the same kind of residue; setting them aside is not a rule the Board applies. Neither 829 nor 723 appears as a number in the Fall 2026 feed, so Planning's figure is not a number match either.

How the count was conformed to the Fall 2026 schedule

The latest published count is the Fall 2024 season (514 weekday trains, every one listed from its first stop). The Fall 2026 weekday schedule was taken by date from the feed: the same 547 Commuter Rail trains run on 54 of the rating's 55 Monday to Friday dates, the north side on typical weekday services and the south side (361 trains, the certified train among them) on the service the feed labels a modified weekday schedule, which is the schedule in effect for the whole rating. Every counted train was matched to the schedule by line, direction and first stop with the departure within ten minutes, after resolving the count's station spellings to the feed's (Littleton/Rte 495, Dedham Corp Center and Porter Square are feed stations under other names; Lynn is a feed station the Fall 2026 schedule no longer serves; Middleborough/Lakeville is no longer a feed station). The Fall 2024 archived feed confirms the method: 434 of the 514 counted trains carry their number in that feed and 421 of them leave at exactly the counted minute, so the count's numbers and times were right when taken and the numbers moved afterwards.

411 counted trains are operated in Fall 2026 and 103 are not. The trains not operated are Fairmount 2, Framingham/Worcester 9, Franklin/Foxboro 10, Greenbush 15, Haverhill 12, Kingston 21, Middleborough/Lakeville 28, Lowell 2, Newburyport/Rockport 2, Providence/Stoughton 2. The Middleborough/Lakeville Line ran no Fall 2026 weekday service (the Fall River/New Bedford Line replaced it); Worcester and Franklin run fewer weekday trains than the count covered (47 and 43 scheduled against 55 and 47 counted); and the Kingston, Greenbush and Haverhill schedules were retimed so that many counted departures have no train within ten minutes. **137 of the 547 Fall 2026 weekday trains have no counted train behind them:** Fairmount 3 of 57, Fall River/New Bedford 57 of 57, Framingham/Worcester 1 of 47, Franklin/Foxboro 6 of 43, Greenbush 13 of 24, Haverhill 23 of 44, Kingston 20 of 25, Lowell 12 of 46, Providence/Stoughton 2 of 74. The Fall River/New Bedford Line has never been counted; Haverhill and Lowell run more weekday trains than the count covered (33 and 37 counted against 44 and 46 scheduled); Kingston and Greenbush were retimed.

Runner up and flip point

The runner up is **Franklin/Foxboro Line train 723**, outbound from South Station at 16:27, peak load 1,036 leaving Ruggles at 16:36, operated in Fall 2026 as train 759 at 16:27. The certified train leads by 28 riders, so a fall of **29 riders** in its peak load (to 1,035) would hand the priority to train 723. The third operated train is Franklin/Foxboro Line 706 at 979.

Train 829 stop by stop

Stop	Time	Boardings	Alightings	Load leaving
South Station	17:40	789	0	789
Back Bay	17:45	182	8	963
Ruggles	17:49	107	6	1,064
Route 128	18:00	19	96	987
Canton Junction	18:06	1	141	847
Sharon	18:12	0	155	692
Mansfield	18:20	4	185	511
Attleboro	18:29	5	260	256
South Attleboro	18:36	3	43	216
Pawtucket/Central Falls	18:40	0	76	140
Providence	18:53	0	97	43
TF Green Airport	19:10	0	30	13
Wickford Junction	19:29	0	14	-1
Total		1,110	1,111	

Most riders board at **South Station** (789 of the 1,110 boardings), then Back Bay and Ruggles. The published count ends the run with a load of -1 at Wickford Junction, a rounding residue of the averaged boardings and alightings; under the convention the count is certified as published and is not adjusted for it.

Previous certification reproduced

The Spring 2018 priority reproduces from the Spring 2018 season of the same file: Framingham/Worcester Line train 508 inbound, peak load 1,384 leaving West Natick, the highest load of that season. The Fall 2026 certified load of 1,064 is 320 riders, 23 percent, below it, and the highest load has moved from an inbound Worcester train to an outbound Providence train in the evening peak.

Why no other train survives

The convention fixes the count (latest season, as published), the measure (peak load, not boardings), the identity of a train across schedules (line, direction, first stop and departure, not number) and the schedule (the weekday service the feed runs on most dates of the rating). Applied together they give one ranked register in which train 829 holds the highest load and is operated, and the ranking is the same whether the departure window is five, ten or thirty minutes. Every other candidate relaxes one fixed point: a shared number instead of a shared slot, a count set aside for a rounding residue, boardings instead of load, or a train the rating no longer runs.